

ownership for centuries you have to maintain your equity.

But there's one thing above all else that bound these families together. They all developed strategies to preserve and enhance their family assets. That is, they all transferred their history, their legacy, and their values down through the generations.

This has meant that each successive generation is ready to take on the challenges of the day and contribute to the success of the family enterprise. That contribution changes over time. But something of the family values and business ethos remain remarkably constant.

The Henokiens will tell you that succession planning is critical.

A PATRIARCH'S IRON GRIP SPELLS TROUBLE FOR A FAMILY BUSINESS

Trying to hold on to control of the family wealth for too long without working out a succession plan with the rest of the family is a recipe for trouble. This often happens when the patriarch of the family wealth is a hard-charging type-A personality. Sumner Redstone matches this profile to a T.

He controls the majority voting stock in Viacom and CBS. He also owns National Amusements, a theater chain that his father started and that became the foundation for the family wealth.

Redstone is a gifted entrepreneur with a laser focus on his work. His life revolves around his businesses, to the detriment of his relationships.

While successful at vanquishing his business rivals, he's also a difficult and combative person by all accounts. He's short with his subordinates.

His estranged son, Brent, filed a lawsuit against him to force the liquidation of his share of the business, worth \$1 billion. He ended up taking a \$240 million buyout. He now lives on a 625-acre ranch in the mountains west of Denver.¹⁵